Introduction

Proteins are the most abundant and diverse organic molecules present in living organisms. The physiological process that takes place in an organism is mediated or assisted by proteins. The name protein has its origin from the Greek word *Proteos*, which could be translated to 'primary' or 'holding first place'.

A single cell contains thousands of proteins, each with a unique structure and function. Though their structures and functions vary, all proteins are made up of a fundamental building block called amino acids. The proteins are made of one or more chains of covalently linked amino acids through peptide bonds.

3.1 Dietary sources of proteins

Proteins can be obtained from both animal and plant sources. The animal sources include milk, meat, fish, liver, egg etc. The plant sources of proteins are pulses, nuts and cereals. Proteins taken in our routine diet are broken down to amino acids (building block) during the process of digestion in stomach. These amino acids are absorbed by the body and used as building blocks to synthesize new proteins once again which depends on the specific physiological requirement of a living organism.

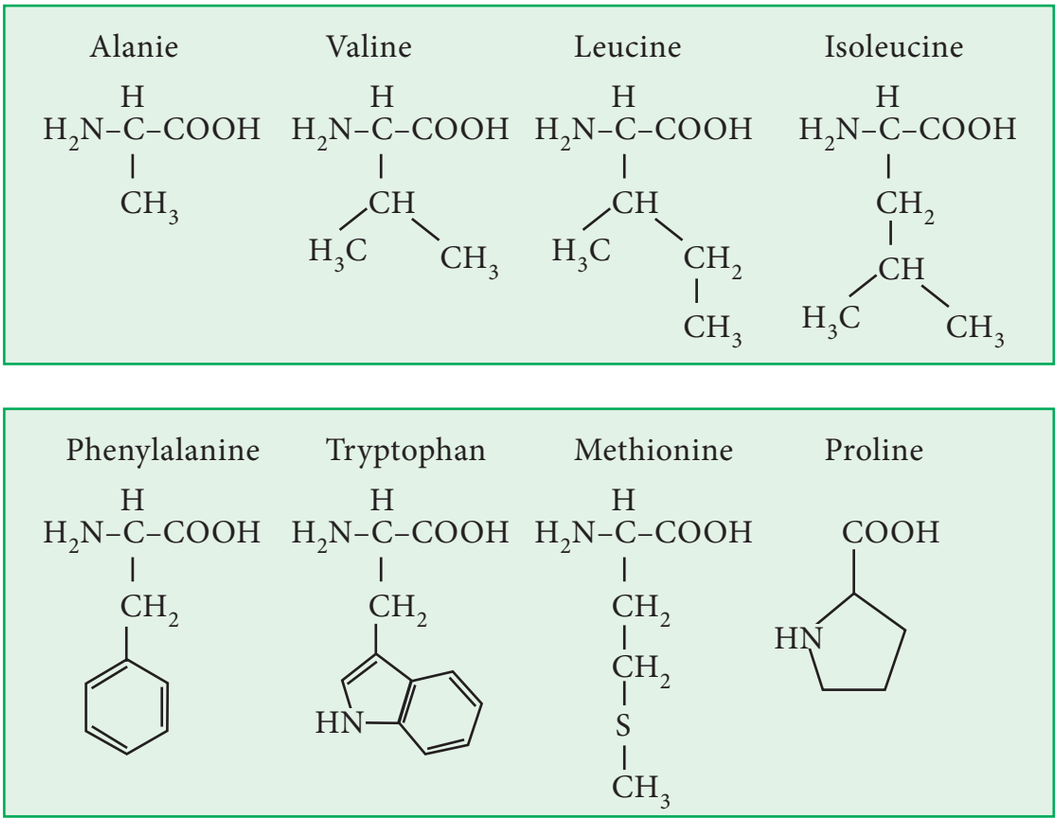

Figure 3.1 Dietary sources of proteins

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